

A PROPOSAL FOR KIRSTY, THE BOYS AND POLLY

THAILAND

Two weeks. Five of us. One adventure we will talk about forever.



BANGKOK • KHAO SOK • KOH TAO • KOH SAMUI

11 TO 25 FEBRUARY • 14 NIGHTS • AROUND £7,350 ALL IN, FLIGHTS INCLUDED

Four stops, *one perfect loop*

City first, while the jet lag works for us. Then deep jungle, then five island nights of learning to dive, then one soft landing on a beach with a pool before the flight home. **No backtracking, no wasted days, and the five of us together for every single one of them.**



- 1 BANGKOK** 12 TO 14 FEB · 3 NIGHTS
 Street food by lantern light, golden temples, ancient ruins by bicycle, and a fish bigger than Polly.
- 2 KHAO SOK** 14 TO 17 FEB · 3 NIGHTS
 Elephants before lunch, then a night on a floating raft house in a rainforest older than the Amazon.
- 3 KOH TAO** 17 TO 22 FEB · 5 NIGHTS
 The boys train as PADI divers, Polly blows her first bubbles, and sharks patrol the shallows.
- 4 KOH SAMUI** 22 TO 25 FEB · 3 NIGHTS
 Swimming pigs, the emerald lagoon at Ang Thong, waterfalls, and a family bungalow with a pool.

GETTING THERE · GULF AIR, BOEING 787

MAN » BKK	11 Feb, 10:15 to 09:20 next day, via Bahrain (2h45 stop)
BKK » MAN	25 Feb, 19:15 to 06:35 next day, via Bahrain (3h15 stop)

£2,867 total for all five of us. That is £573 each, return, to the other side of the world.

WHY FEBRUARY IS THE MOMENT

Peak dry season: 32 degrees, calm seas, the clearest water of the year. Whale sharks start cruising past Koh Tao in February. Manchester, meanwhile, will be 4 degrees and raining sideways.



Three days in the city that *never slows down*

We land at breakfast time with a whole city to eat. Bangkok is gold leaf and diesel, incense and chilli smoke, seven million scooters and the best street food on the planet at **£1 to £2 a plate**.

- **Yaowarat Road food crawl.** Chinatown after dark: neon, lanterns, charcoal woks. We graze stall to stall and eat like royalty for the price of one Manchester takeaway.
- **Dawn longtail through the Thonburi canals.** Old Bangkok on stilts, monks collecting alms, the city waking up around us.
- **The Grand Palace and Wat Pho.** A 46 metre reclining Buddha covered in gold. Polly will not believe the size of its feet.
- **Ayutthaya by train.** Third class tickets, windows open. Then bicycles through a ruined 400 year old royal capital, temples wrapped in tree roots.
- **Optional detour: Lopburi, the monkey city.** A town run by macaques. The boys will never stop talking about it.

WHERE WE SLEEP

Family rooms in Silom or Sukhumvit, close to the Skytrain: £45 to £65 a night for all five of us.

WOW MOMENT

The fish bigger than Polly

Bungsamran Lake is home to Mekong giant catfish over **50 kilos**. Around £30 a peg with tackle and a guide included. When one takes the bait it will take two of us on the rod, twenty minutes of shaking arms, and one photograph that gets framed. **Polly weighs less than this fish.**

Street feast **£2 a head**

Ayutthaya train **about £1**

Catfish peg **£30**



The night we sleep *on the lake*

A short flight south (Bangkok to Surat Thani, about £40 each) and the world changes completely: **Khao Sok is rainforest older than the Amazon**, limestone towers wrapped in jungle, and a flooded emerald valley called Cheow Lan Lake.

- **Khao Sok Elephant Sanctuary.** A half day feeding and walking with rescued elephants. Ethical, no riding, hands on. **£35 to £45 each** and worth every penny of it.
- **Overnight in a floating raft house.** 500 Rai Floating Resort, out on the lake itself. Wooden cabins on pontoons, limestone karsts straight out of emerald water, and you swim right off your own porch. **£60 to £90 a night for all five.**
- **Dawn wildlife safari by longtail.** Gibbons, hornbills, langurs, macaques, and if the lake is kind, wild elephants at the waterline.
- **Freshwater fishing for snakehead.** Aggressive, hard fighting, spectacular. **£40 to £60 for a half day.**
- **Jungle trek** under 300 metre cliffs, through forest that was already ancient when the dinosaurs went.

WOW MOMENT

Waking up on the water

Mist on the lake. Limestone towers on every side, glowing pink in the first light. **Gibbons singing the valley awake**, the strangest and most beautiful sound in Asia. You roll out of bed, take three steps, and dive into warm emerald water before breakfast. No wifi. Nobody will mind.

Flight south **£40 each**

Raft house **from £60**

Elephants **£35 to £45**



The island where the boys *become divers*

Ferry across from Surat Thani (about £20 each) to Turtle Island: the cheapest, friendliest place on Earth to learn to dive. **Warm 29 degree water, 20 metre visibility, and dive schools that have trained half the planet.**

- **PADI Open Water for the boys.** Three to four days of pool drills and real ocean dives, about **£250 each**. A qualification that lasts a lifetime, earned at 14 and 15.
- **Polly gets her moment too.** Bubblemaker or Discover Scuba in the shallows, about **£40**, with an instructor all to herself.
- **Shark Bay snorkelling.** Blacktip reef sharks cruising waist deep water. Completely harmless, completely unforgettable.
- **Sail Rock.** The Gulf's best dive site. From February, whale sharks, the biggest fish in the sea, pass through.
- **Private longtail charter** for a day around the island's coves, **£80 to £120**. Plus a deep sea fishing run: barracuda, trevally, Spanish mackerel.
- **Sunset hike to John-Suwan viewpoint**, where two bays meet in a ribbon of sand.

WHERE WE SLEEP

Dive school lodges from £10 to £20 a night (discounted with the courses), or a Sairee Beach guesthouse at £30 to £50.

WOW MOMENT

Their first breath underwater

Somewhere around day three, ten metres down over a coral garden, the boys will look at each other and realise they are **actually doing this**. Certified divers before they can drive. And they will always remember it was this trip, and this family, that made it happen.

Ferry **£20 each**

Open Water **£250**

Beds from **£10 a night**



Pigs, palms and one last *emerald lagoon*

One easy ferry hop (about £15 each) to the soft landing: a **family bungalow with a pool** in Lamai or Maenam, £50 to £80 a night, and three days of the greatest hits before we fly home.

- **Pig Island.** A longtail out to Koh Madsum, where the pigs paddle out to meet the boat, then snorkelling off Koh Tan. About **£30 each**. Polly may refuse to leave.
- **Ang Thong Marine Park.** Forty two jungle islands rising out of turquoise sea. We kayak between the karsts and climb to the emerald lagoon, a sealed lake of green glass hidden inside an island.
- **Na Muang waterfalls.** Purple granite, jungle pools, one last freshwater swim.
- **The wind down.** Pool, beach, massages for Mum, mango sticky rice for everyone.
- **The smooth exit.** Fly Samui to Bangkok on the 25th, connecting neatly to the 19:15 flight home. No mad dashes.

WOW MOMENT

Pigs that swim out to say hello

The boat noses into the shallows off Koh Madsum and the welcome committee arrives: **actual pigs, actually swimming**, snouts up like little pink tugboats. It is the single silliest, happiest thing in the Gulf of Thailand, and it is ours for about £30 a head.

Ferry **£15 each**

Pig Island **£30 each**

Pool bungalow **from £50**

What £7,350 *actually* buys

Not a package deal, not a resort with a kids club. **A fortnight on the other side of the world, flights included, built entirely around the five of us.** Here is the whole thing, honestly costed, with room built in.

£105

PER PERSON, PER DAY,
EVERYTHING INCLUDED

£68

AVERAGE NIGHT FOR
ALL FIVE OF US

14

NIGHTS ACROSS FOUR
BASES

2

DIVE LICENCES THAT
LAST A LIFETIME



Street food **£1 to £2 a plate**

Family feast out **£25 to £35**

No night over **£100** for all five

For scale: the flights are £573 each, return, on a Boeing 787. The other £4,500 covers every bed, every meal, every boat, two PADI certifications, an elephant sanctuary and a monster catfish. Plenty of families spend more than that on ten days under a Spanish sun lounger, **and nobody writes stories about the sun lounger.**

Book these three things first

- The raft house.** 500 Rai on Cheow Lan Lake sells out for February. This is the trip's crown jewel: secure it first.
- The Koh Tao dive school.** February is peak season. Reserve the boys' Open Water course and the family rooms together.
- Internal flights.** Bangkok to Surat Thani, and Samui to Bangkok on the 25th, while they are still about £40.

Everything else can be booked on the ground, often cheaper, always flexible.

THE HONEST SMALL PRINT

Prices are researched estimates in pounds for February and will drift a little either way. The budget already includes a cushion in the extras line.

THE CLOSING ARGUMENT



Fourteen mornings we will *never forget*

- ✦ *Mist rising off Cheow Lan Lake, watched from our own front porch*
- ✦ *Gibbons singing the valley awake while breakfast cooks*
- ✦ *The boys' first breath underwater, and the day they qualify*
- ✦ *Twenty minutes of bent rod, then a catfish heavier than Polly*
- ✦ *Pink pigs paddling out to meet our boat*
- ✦ *The emerald lagoon at Ang Thong, green glass in a ring of stone*
- ✦ *Street food under red lanterns, five plates for a tenner*

All that is left to do is say yes.

BANGKOK · KHAO SOK · KOH TAO · KOH SAMUI

11 TO 25 FEBRUARY · GULF AIR FROM MANCHESTER · AROUND £7,350 ALL IN

FIRST MOVES: BOOK THE RAFT HOUSE, THE DIVE SCHOOL AND THE INTERNAL FLIGHTS